Chettiar firms were richer and more global than the Marwaris, but by the 1960s the prominence of these firms had fallen and Marwaris formed a fourth of the business elite.[57] By 2014, there was only one Chettiar name among India's hundred most rich business leaders compared to a staggering thirty-two Marwaris, the maximum from a single community.[58] Socially conservative and financially brilliant, the Marwaris today dominate the world of big business, and also small business in specific sectors such as trade. The core Marwari investment and diasporic network grew within India, arguably because Rajasthan was not a coastal region with historic international trading connections. This set them apart from the other community synonymous with the world of Indian business: the Gujaratis.

The Enterprising Gujarati

Compared to Marwari commercial brilliance that was achieved by a few groups in Rajasthan with a large internal network, Gujarati commercial success has been more secular and transnational. Gujarati entrepreneurship stretches widely from Assam to Tamil Nadu and East Africa to the US. It goes beyond the traditional *Vaish*–Jain folds and also cuts across religions as it had hosted the Parsis, as discussed earlier, and commercially successful Muslims, discussed in a later section. It also touches most areas within Gujarat, from Kachchh in the west to Saurashtra in the middle and Ahmedabad and Surat in the east.

Gujarat's coastline of over 1000 kilometres is an important part of this story. The coastal towns of Mandvi, Dwarka, Porbandar, Somnath, Diu, Bharuch and Surat have historically been conduits of spatial mobility for merchants and pilgrims. The towns of the hinterland were equally important for internal trading routes, especially for cotton. Since the 15th century, Ahmedabad, and its famous Manek Chowk, began to gain commercial prominence. This long history of trade and exposure to traders from other parts of the world allowed for the idea of business to be associated with respectability. A French traveller in the early 19th century commented that trade was not taboo in Gujarat, and even Brahmins were 'excellent men of